

Figures of speech

Figures of speech are useful language tools that allow a writer or speaker to persuade, emphasize, impress, or create a mental image. Words and phrases are used out of their literal contexts to create different, heightened effects. When a person claims to be “starving,” for example, that person is unlikely to be dying of hunger; rather, he or she is simply very hungry.

• Try to **invent new, interesting metaphors** when writing rather than copying existing ones.

Alliteration

The same letter or sound is used at the start of multiple words for effect.

Catherine carefully combined cold coffee cake and kiwi fruit.

Simile

The words *like* or *as* are used to compare two things.

She is **as plump as a peach**, but she moves **like a ballerina**.

Metaphor

One thing is described as being a different thing, resulting in a comparison between the two.

Her cheeks **are sun-blushed apples**.

Euphemism

A mild word or phrase is substituted for a word or phrase that might cause offense.

She has **ample proportions** (she is overweight).

Pun

Also known as word play, the multiple meanings of a word are used to create humor.

She gave me her measurements as **a round figure**.

Hyperbole

A statement is grossly exaggerated.

She said she could **eat a rhinoceros**.

Personification

An object or animal is given human qualities.

The food **called** to her.

Oxymoron

Two terms are used together that contradict each other.

The pie looked **terribly tasty**.

Onomatopoeia

A word is used that mimics the sound of what it stands for.

She **burped** noisily.

Anaphora

A word or phrase is repeated at the start of successive clauses for emphasis.

She ate the pie; **she ate** the cake; **she ate** the kiwi fruit.

Irony

One thing is said but the opposite thing is meant, usually for humor or emphasis.

I admired her **charming** table manners (her manners were poor).

Understatement

Something is made out to be smaller or less important than it really is.

She said she had enjoyed her **light lunch**.